

# Boston: a private city goes public

*Kevin White is passing on to his successor not only a much different view from City Hall than White inherited but a 'new Boston' as well*

By Robert Campbell  
Globe Correspondent

**T**he close of the Kevin White era in Boston, soon to arrive, is the kind of milestone by which we like to measure change in the world. Looking backward over those 16 years, it is obvious that the face of this city has changed as rapidly as at any time in its history.

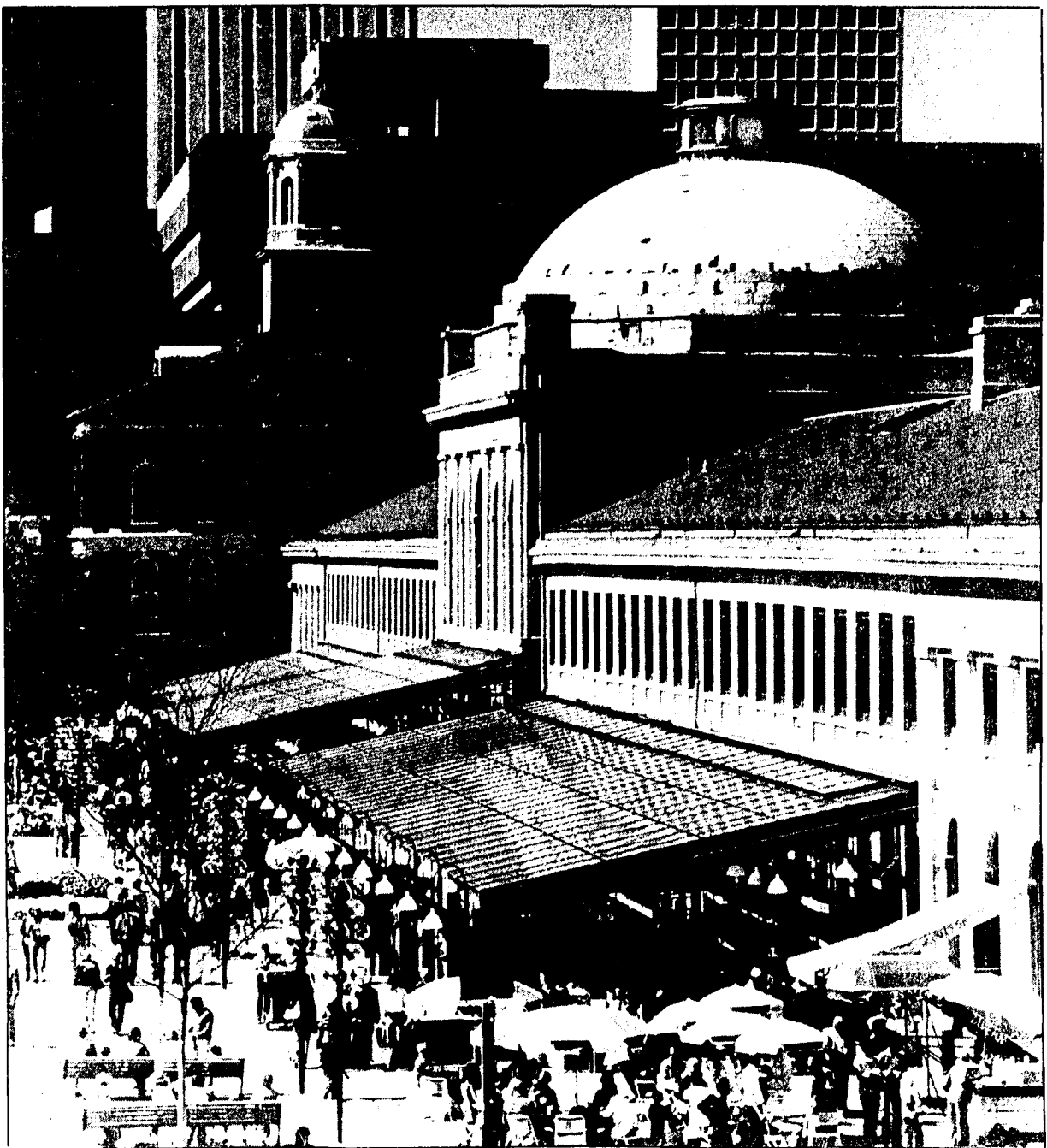
One index of the size of change is the simple fact that the office Mayor White moved into wasn't in the new City Hall. City Hall, the pride of the renewal surge of the 1960s under Mayor John Collins and Edward Logue, wasn't finished in January 1968. Nor was there a Hancock Tower, a Faneuil Hall Marketplace, a Christian Science Center. Nor was there a residential neighborhood on the Boston Waterfront, which was then still a row of derelict structures. Nor was there an architectural preservation movement to speak of. Hard as it is now to believe, hardly anyone in Boston or America had at that time eaten a meal in a chic restaurant recycled from a warehouse or mill or wharf, featuring an esthetic of rough, sandblasted wood beams and brick walls, hanging plants, polished

brass and weathered commercial signs.

A time lapse film of Boston during that 16-year era would be fascinating. We would see, as the years unrolled, flags and sails flower along the waterfront wharves. A congestion of trucks near the old Quincy Market would suddenly vanish, to be replaced by crowds of people, trees and cobblestones. Old downtown buildings, some of them superb, would disappear like blips on an Asteroids screen, leaving vacant holes out of which a forest of towers would spring. (In 1967, when White was first elected, the old Custom House, State Street Bank and New England Merchants Bank were the only completed office towers downtown.) Out on Columbia Point, a dark red new university would grow, followed by an angular white memorial to a President. And a sliver of blue glass would flash briefly beside Trinity Church, then seem to moul, then flash again: the Hancock Tower shedding and then renewing its glass scales.

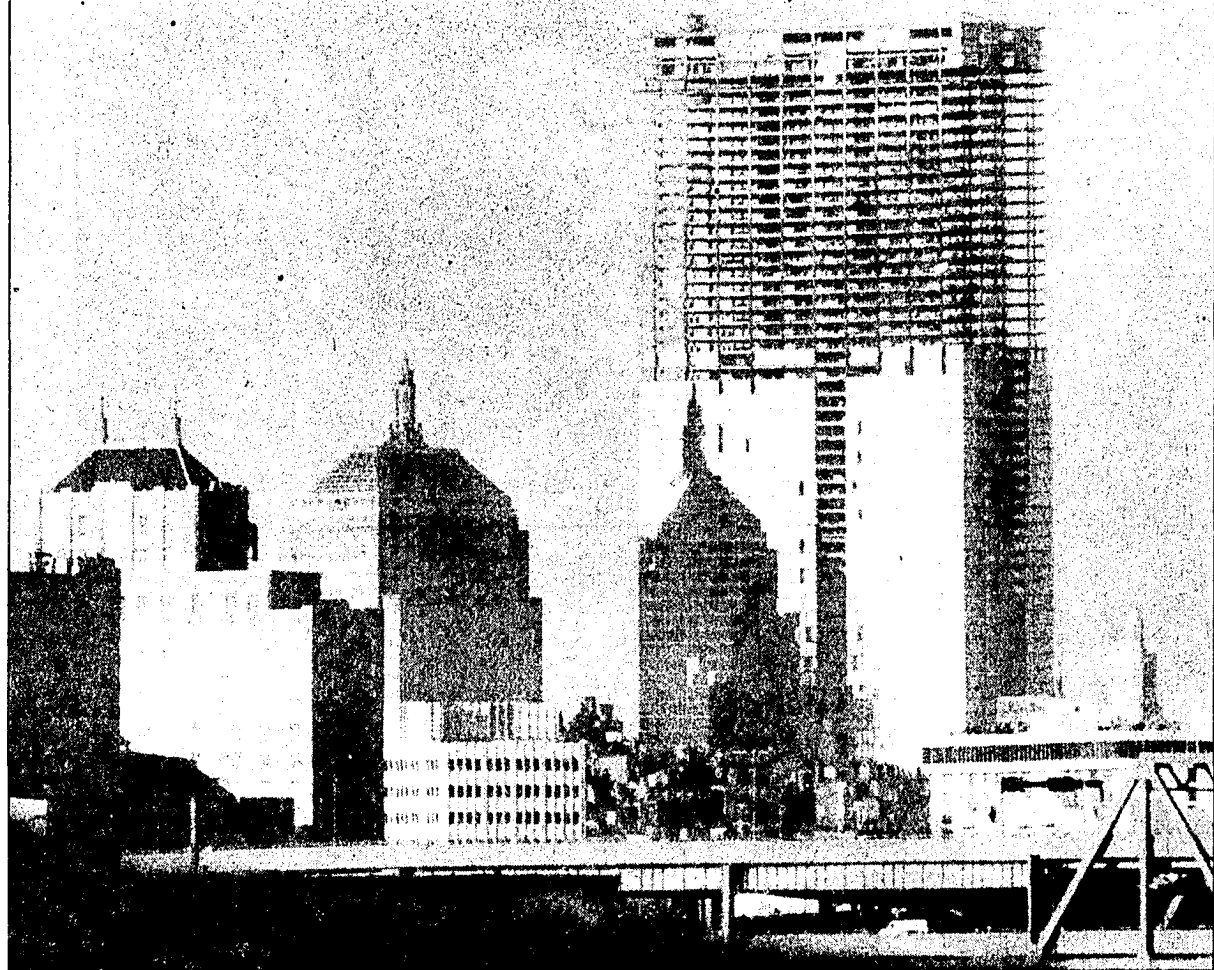
All this refers mostly, of course, to central Boston. Things didn't change so vividly in many of the neighborhoods, but that's a separate tale.

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Quincy Marketplace: part of the "new Boston" with roots in the old.

GLOBE FILE PHOTO



In 1972, the new John Hancock building rises in the shadow of the old.

GLOBE FILE PHOTO

# Boston

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## Many forces at work

What happened to architecture in central Boston can't be summed up under any one head. Too many forces were at work. But there's at least one overall change that helps to organize these years, a change that many of the little changes were part of. That is the shift in Boston from a rather private to a comparatively public city.

A private city is one like, say, Dallas. Everything in Dallas seems to happen behind corporate doors, or tall hedges, or mirror-glass walls. Social life is a barbecue out back, a dinner at the club. Downtown Dallas is only for working and its streets have no public life.

A more public city, like Boston, is one in which for some reason people feel they own the place. Instead of withdrawing behind walls, they pour out to occupy the streets and parks and squares and waterfronts, making these urban places into public living rooms. Public cities offer something beyond the private world so typical of 20th-century Americans — beyond the family at its TV, the single alone in her condo with her Garfield poster and stereo, the automobile driver with his voyeur's view of the world. Public cities possess a public realm, where citizens of all kinds can come together to see and be seen, to experience unexpected encounters and to enjoy the drama of simply gathering as a community.

Few American cities are like that. San Francisco is one, and Boston is becoming another.

To have a public city you need public spaces. Downtown Crossing, the Waterfront Park and promenades, the new Post Office Square, Navy Yard Park, Government Center Plaza and Faneuil Hall Marketplace are all new additions to the public city. The dreary attempt to improve Copley Square at the beginning of the White era contrasts interestingly with the effort now in progress, which is oriented far more toward people and activity.

## 'Age of Circuses' over

Looking back over White's 16 years, it's obvious that the public era began with what you might call Boston's Age of Circuses. These were all those slightly feverish, slightly concocted public celebrations — Summerthing, Boston 200, the Kite Flight, harbor cruises, the River Festival, the Tall Ships, First Night. They were a response to the fact that the city had become unfashionable, had been deserted by the long middle-class flight to the suburbs. Those who still loved Boston felt it had to be repackaged and remarketed. The circuses were a hearty, Rotarian attempt to market the city as a festive delight. A lot of cities were doing the same — John Lindsey's New York, most notably. Many still are, but not Boston. The Age of Circuses is over because Boston has revived to the point at which they're not needed, and the best of them have simply evolved into institutions.

It was at the height of the circus era that there occurred the most important single event in Boston architecture during the White years, the opening of Faneuil Hall Marketplace in 1975.

In a sense the Marketplace is the biggest of the circuses, but it's far more. James Rouse, the developer, and Ben Thompson, the architect, created what is essentially theater. The Marketplace is a magnificent theatrical representation of city life for the enjoyment of people from the suburbs who had learned to fear the real city.

Many suburbanites saw the city as

dirty, corrupt, congested, disorienting and filled with strange and perhaps dangerous people. Yet they were finding the suburbs one-dimensional. Faneuil Hall Marketplace solved their dilemma: a technicolor city that is clean, safe, cheery; a city in which Mario Lanza is probably going to burst into song from behind the cheeses. The Marketplace is a kind of halfway house for people who are undergoing withdrawal from the car culture and learning to love the city again. It can be mocked for its artificiality, but the mockers are foolish because the Marketplace proved to be the most successful regenerator of public life in downtown Boston.

## A symbol of preservation

The Marketplace was important too for the way in which its recycling insisted on the importance of memory to the experience of place. Boston had lost much of its past in the 1960s. Urban renewal savaged whole sections of town — Scollay Square, the West End. Too much of the known was disappearing and people were becoming anxious. The Marketplace was one symptom of the historic preservation movement, which now began to stir.

There had always been people concerned about preserving architecture of the past, but they had tended to limit their attention to a few historic monuments. Now, a far more ambitious ethic emerged, the notion that the world of buildings and public spaces should be regarded in the same way as the holdings of a museum, as a priceless collection of which the present generation are the curators. Boston was by no means in the forefront of this movement. The National Historic Preservation Act was passed in 1965. Not until 1975, after years of debate, did Boston finally get a Landmarks Commission.

Since then the Landmarks Commission has become central to the architectural evolution of Boston. A good city is a delicate balance between hope and memory. It must provide reassurance that a better world is possible in the future, while simultaneously respecting everything from the past that nourishes our roots and our identity. Therefore, it must change, and it must remain the same. The Landmarks Commission has become the custodian of this paradox, the broker between the forces of preservation and those of change.

Those forces clashed abruptly in Boston throughout the 1970s, and some of the new architecture dramatizes the clash. Exchange Place, now under construction on State street, will consist of the facade of the ornate old Exchange Building grafted, like a mask, onto the front of a new mirror-glass skyscraper. Here old and new will be brought too violently together.

But old and new have also sung in harmony in Boston. Increasingly, under pressure from all those citizens who now correctly act as if they owned the public city, architects and developers are having to learn to suture rather than rupture architectural tissue.

One example of this is the revolution in the design of downtown office towers. In the 1960s and early 1970s, Boston's new towers typically were simple rectangles in floor plan, despite the fact that Boston's street plan is anything but grid. These squared-up towers were then dumped onto their irregular lots willy-nilly, and whatever odd parcels of land happened to be left over were called plazas. Public-relations nonsense blathered about how this windy, uninhabitable acreage was being given back to the people. The First National Bank, One Beacon Street and One Boston Place are three prime examples.

With the rise of the idea of the public city, attitudes changed. As author William Whyte says, the busy street, not the vacant plaza, is the river of life in the city. Recent office towers have tended to use their bulk to strengthen the shape of the

street space, bending with Boston's angular pattern rather than ignoring it, often including shops and restaurants to maintain the vitality of the street edge. Devonshire Towers on Washington street, the Transportation Building now under construction and the Philip Johnson-designed proposal for Fort Hill Place are good examples.

Fitting into the street shapes, of course, isn't enough. Many of the new and proposed towers are banal in appearance and overwhelming in number and size. The ethic of public concern and preservationism has plenty of work still cut out for it.

One Boston building sums up much that has happened in these years and provides a litmus test of changing architectural attitudes. How you regard it reveals something of your own priorities in architecture. This is the addition to the Ritz-Carlton Hotel, by the Chicago office of Skidmore, Owings and Merrill.

There are two ways to see the Ritz addition. You can see it as a slightly kitsch, rather plastic-looking imitation of the original Ritz-Carlton next door, as a building that is neither traditional nor modern, but a mongrel compromise. Or you can see it as a building that is so right in size, placement, scale and materials that it almost vanishes into the weave of the city. Both views are correct. The question is which one you consider more important.

## Ritz right in an important way

The Ritz is no more nor less than the product of the forces that have been shaping Boston. It wants to fit in, wants to do its job of forming an edge to the two very important public spaces it fronts on, Commonwealth Mall and the Public Garden. It wants to respect its historic context. It isn't (as it might well have been had it been built 20 years earlier) a tower behind a fountain and plaza. It isn't (as it might have been) a mirror-glass box or a concrete sculpture. It's the right height, the right mass, the right mix of colors, the right roofline, the right setback from the street, the right rhythm and scale to bring Commonwealth avenue to a firm closure, turn the corner and merge with the Ritz. It's also, unfortunately, an instance of paper-thin use of traditional materials and awkward detailing that remind you that good manners aren't the same thing as talent.

The important thing, to me anyway, is that the Ritz is right in the ways that count, the public ways. It is typical of the effort of many architects to learn again to use buildings as they were used in the past — that is, to aggregate them into streets and cities rather than design them as isolated ego-objects. The Ritz, as a product of the public forces that are shaping Boston at the end of the White era, is 80 percent the right building, which is a lot more than usual in our era.

Its faults are revealing, too. Its timidity and confusion remind us that we don't possess an accepted style in architecture any more. The Ritz isn't boring and abstract like much modernism, but it's flat and weak compared to much traditional architecture. It's a set-designer's building. There has been a loss of faith by nearly everyone in modernism and its often minimal esthetic, but we don't yet have a convincing replacement.

Maybe that's part of the reason for the fact that, despite the fame of Boston as a center of architecture and the progress in our understanding of the city and in our respect for the past, there has nevertheless not been, in my view, a single truly distinguished, recent world-class work of architecture in central Boston. Sadly enough, Mayor White won't have that to look back on. Maybe his successor will be luckier.

Robert Campbell is *The Globe's* architecture critic.